A Post-symbolism BJP: Muslim Representation, Ideological Maximalism and Electoral Winnability

Much has been made of the symbolism of the BJP not fielding any Muslim candidates from the crucial state of UP in the national elections of 2014 and 2019 and the state assembly polls of 2017. From Sikander Bakht to Najma Heptulla and Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi to Shahnawaz Hussain, the BJP has always had symbolic Muslim leaders in the past. Yet, it has hardly ever fielded Muslim candidates in UP over the past three decades between 1991 and 2019. Consider this: the BJP fielded zero Muslim candidates in the state when it first became a rising power there at the height of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement in 1991. Even in 1996, it fielded only one Muslim candidate each in 1998 and 1999. This phase of UP politics coincided with the Vajpayee era of coalition politics when the BJP went up to a high of two Muslim candidates in 2004—the highest number (2.5 per cent) that the party has ever fielded in UP. Of course, such representation was always only a symbolic gesture. Muslim leaders were never a major part of its political mobilisation.

What the BJP did, first in the UP assembly election of 2017, and then in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, was to do away with the symbolism (see Table 5.1). It took a political call that it did not need Muslims to win elections. In fact, in purely electoral terms, doing away with the symbolism and being unambiguous in its messaging increased the BJP's winnability, as the data shows. This was particularly true in Muslim-significant areas. While the party decided that it did not need Muslim leaders to draw voters, it did feel that a symbolic Muslim presence was important for governance. So, though the BJP did not field a single Muslim candidate in the 2017 assembly polls, Yogi Adityanath did appoint a Muslim minister, former first-class cricketer Mohsin Raza, as minister for Minority Welfare, Muslim Waqf and Haj.[17] Similarly, in the Lok Sabha, though the BJP did not field a single Muslim from UP in 2019, it appointed Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi as the cabinet minister in charge of Minority Affairs. Naqvi, the first elected Muslim for the BJP in the Lok Sabha in 1998,[18] had also served as a minister in the Vajpayee government, along with Shahnawaz Hussain, who served as a